



Memorable win: Pakistan dominated arch-rival India with a stunning 2017 Champions Trophy victory at The Oval, fuelled by Fakhar Zaman's brilliant century. GETTY IMAGES

challenging project because many doubted it would be completed," said Mohsin Naqvi, the PCB chairman. "Everyone will be remembered because it was due to your untiring effort and the help of God Almighty that this project is completed," he said as the stadium was officially reopened.

While the PCB is confident of hosting a successful event, questions remain about whether the tournament will capture enough interest in Pakistan, given that the much-anticipated India-Pakistan clash will be played elsewhere.

Ehsan Mani, a former ICC chairman and former chief of the PCB, has expressed disappointment with how the global body handled the situation. He believes the ICC

should have engaged with representatives from the BCCI and PCB much earlier rather than leaving it until the last minute.

"When the tournament was awarded three years ago, and the political situation between the two countries remained tense, it was important for the ICC to plan things better and come up with a solution much earlier," Mani told this publication. With the event split into two legs, teams are also concerned about the extensive travel involved. As one administrator pointed out, "It would certainly be a challenge for the teams to crisscross from one country to another and then play back-to-back games."

Ramiz, however, does not see this as a significant issue. Drawing on his experience from the 1989 Nehru Cup, he recalled, "I remember travelling several thousand kilometres (six cities) in about 10 days during the tournament, and even then, we went on to win. Only three venues will be hosting matches

this time, so travel won't be excessive. Dubai is just a couple of hours away, and teams are used to such journeys. So, it should not matter much..."

The ICC has scrapped its usual pre-tournament captains' photoshoot and mandatory press conference to minimise travel disruptions.

Another notable aspect is the absence of Indian officials from the list of 12 umpires and match referees appointed by the ICC. Javagal Srinath, the only Indian in the ICC Elite Panel of Match Referees, and Nitin Menon, India's sole representative in the ICC Elite Panel of Umpires, have opted out, citing 'personal reasons'.

Despite the event's global status, it is unlikely that Indian fans will be permitted to travel to Pakistan for matches, mirroring the situation during the 2023 ODI World Cup, when Pakistani fans were denied visas. Even Pakistani media representatives were granted limited